

Experiment 2

Zoho Creator Report

Setting Up a Zoho Creator Account: Exploring the Platform Architecture and Interface

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1. Introduction

Zoho Creator is a cloud-based, low-code application development platform that allows individuals and organizations to design, deploy, and manage custom business applications with minimal hand-written code. This report documents the process of setting up a trial Zoho Creator account and walks through the main sections of the Creator console, based on a set of screenshots captured while exploring the dashboard after account creation. Each screenshot is paired with an explanation of what the corresponding module does and how it fits into the platform as a whole.

2. Objective

The aim of this exercise is to get hands-on exposure to the Zoho Creator platform by registering a trial account, exploring its low-code environment, and understanding how the console's modules — spanning application development, deployment, and account-wide administration — work together. Specific goals for the exercise were:

- Register a free Zoho Creator trial account and create a sample application.
- Move through the DEVELOP, DEPLOY, and MANAGE sections of the console and note what each is for.
- Identify the purpose of each module — Applications, Microservices, Environments, Mobile, Portal, Users, Organization, Governance, Metrics, Operations, and Billing.
- Record the overall platform layout through annotated screenshots for later reference.

3. Steps Followed During Account Setup

Step	Action Performed
1	Signed up for a free Zoho Creator trial account using a college email address.
2	Logged into the Creator console and viewed the 'Applications' dashboard, where a sample application named 'My first Creator app' was created.
3	Opened the 'Microservices' module to see how modular, AI-ready components are built.
4	Checked the 'Environments' page to understand the Stage-to-Production deployment flow.
5	Reviewed the 'Mobile' and 'Portal' sections to see the external distribution and self-service access options.
6	Looked at 'Users' to confirm the account holder's role and access status.
7	Went to 'Organization' to check company profile, branding, and preference settings.
8	Explored 'Governance' to see the available security policy and authentication options.
9	Reviewed 'Metrics', 'Operations', and 'Billing' to understand analytics, administrative controls, and subscription details.

4. Platform / System Architecture

The Zoho Creator interface is built around two functional groups that stay visible in the left-hand navigation panel no matter which screen is open:

Category	Modules	Purpose
DEVELOP	Applications, Microservices	Build and manage applications; assemble modular microservices for third-party integrations and AI features.
DEPLOY	Environments, Mobile, Portal	Manage Stage/Production environments, distribute mobile apps, and offer a self-service portal to external users.
MANAGE	Users, Organization, Governance, Metrics, Operations, Billing	Administer user access, organization profile, security policy, usage analytics, operational settings, and subscription/billing details.

Read together, these three layers describe the full lifecycle of a Creator application: it is first **developed** as an application or microservice, then **deployed** across environments and delivery channels, and finally **managed** centrally for access, security, monitoring, and billing. The diagram below lays out this structure, showing which modules sit under each category and how the three categories connect into one continuous lifecycle.

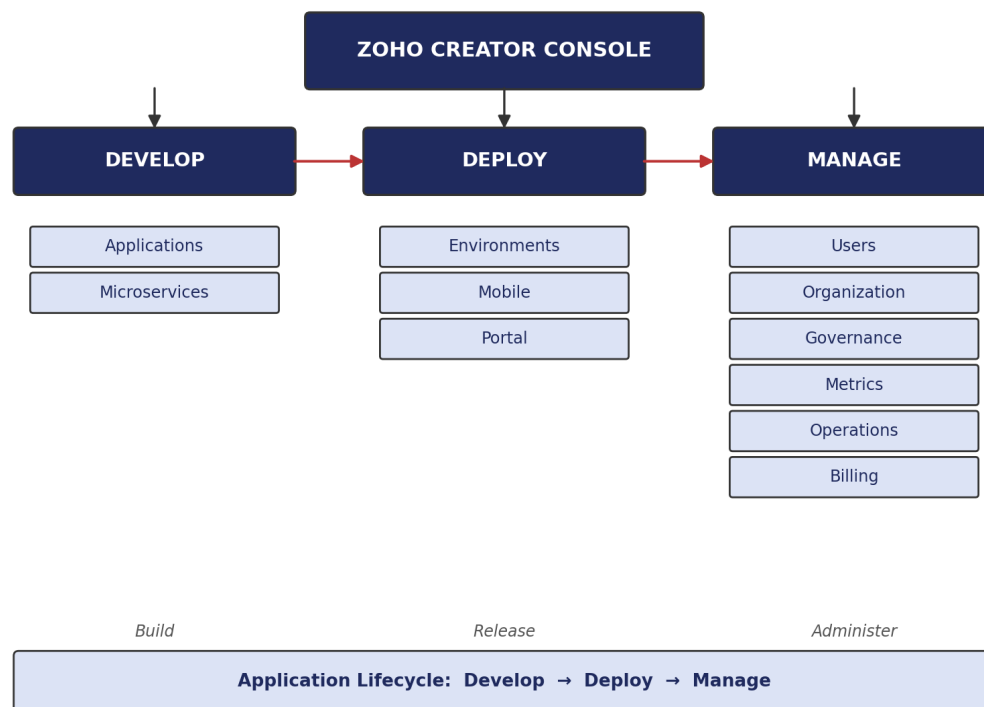


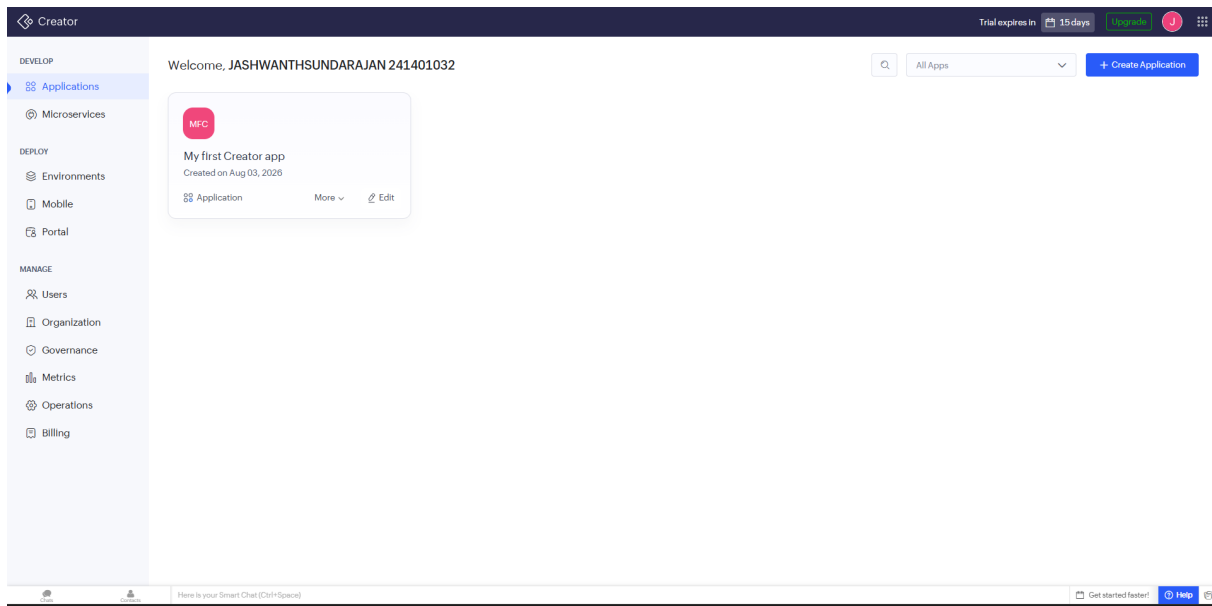
Figure A: Zoho Creator platform architecture — Develop, Deploy, and Manage layers and their modules.

5. Screenshot Walkthrough

This section walks through the Zoho Creator console screen by screen, in the order it was explored during account setup. Each figure carries a short title and an explanation of what is on screen and how that module fits into the DEVELOP–DEPLOY–MANAGE structure described above.

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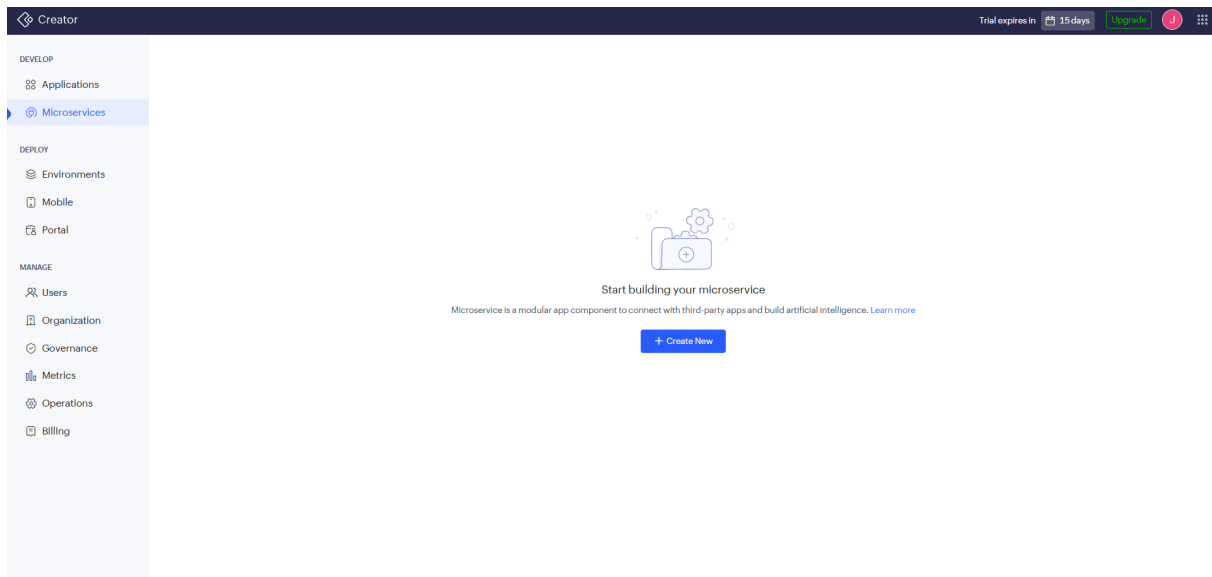
Figure 1: Applications Dashboard



This is the landing page of the 'Applications' section — the first screen shown right after logging in. It greets the user by account name ('Welcome, JASHWANTHSUNDARAJAN 241401032') and shows the sample application created during setup, 'My first Creator app', dated Aug 03, 2026, displayed as a card with an auto-generated 'MFC' icon and quick links for Application, More, and Edit.

The top-right corner holds a search bar, an 'All Apps' filter, and a '+ Create Application' button for starting new projects, while the top bar shows the trial countdown ('Trial expires in 15 days') and an Upgrade option. The left-hand navigation panel seen here — grouped into DEVELOP (Applications, Microservices), DEPLOY (Environments, Mobile, Portal), and MANAGE (Users, Organization, Governance, Metrics, Operations, Billing) — stays fixed throughout the console and forms the backbone of the rest of this report.

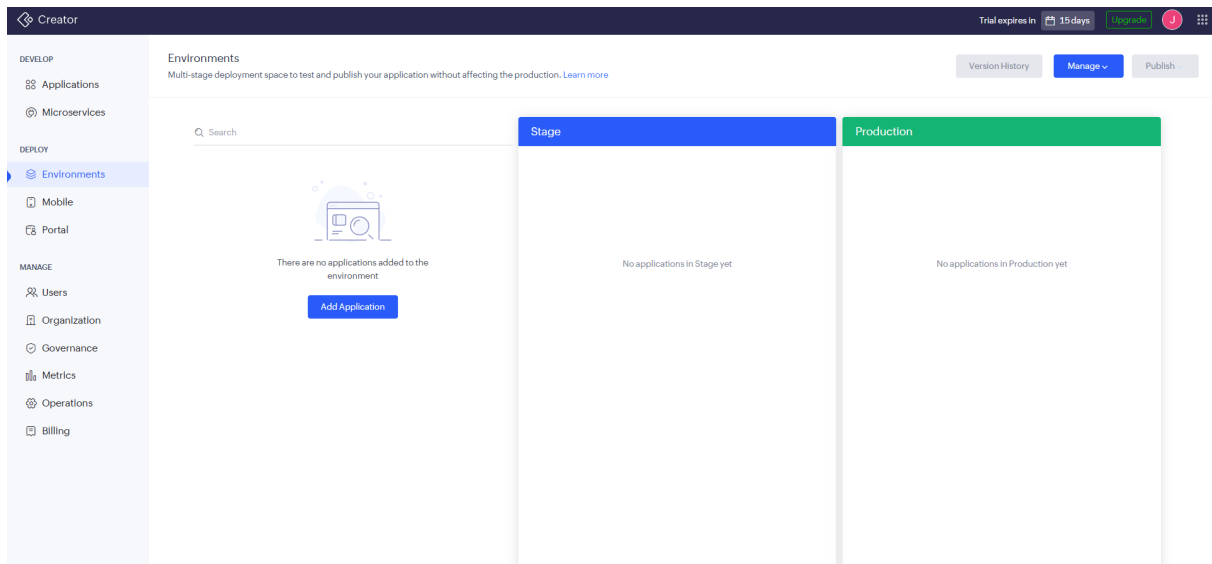
Figure 2: Microservices Panel



This screen shows the 'Microservices' module, the second entry under DEVELOP. Since no microservice has been created yet on this trial account, the platform shows an empty state with the heading 'Start building your microservice' and a short explanation: a microservice is a modular app component used to connect with third-party apps and build artificial intelligence, with a 'Learn more' link for further reading and a '+ Create New' button to begin.

In practice, microservices let a Creator application be broken into small, reusable units of logic — for example, a payment-validation service or an AI recommendation engine — that can be plugged into one or more applications without duplicating the same code, which keeps the overall system easier to maintain.

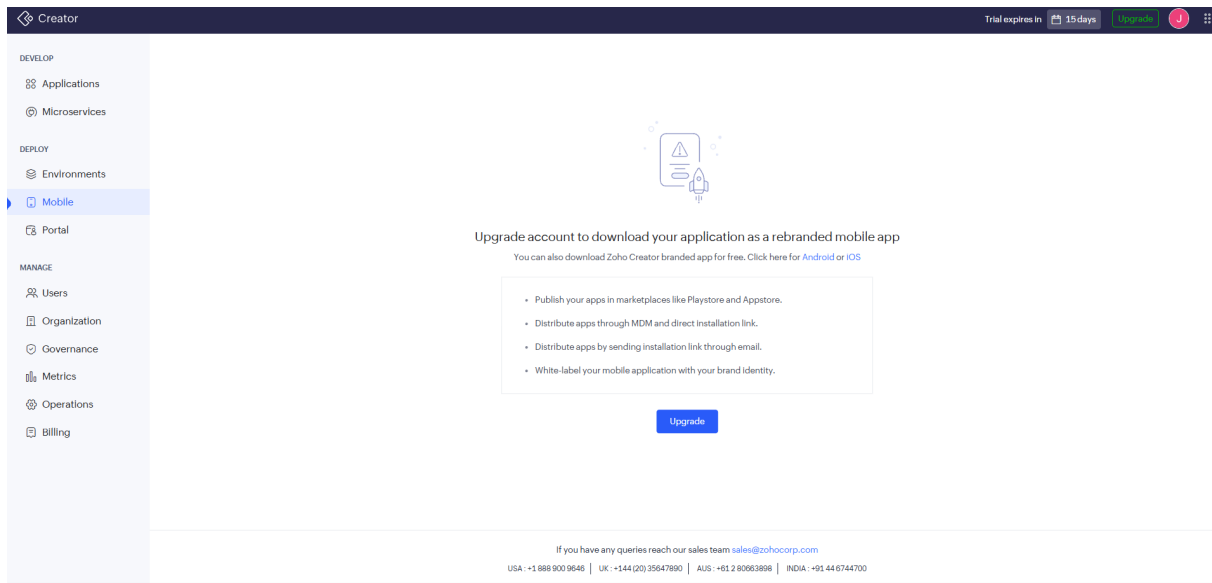
Figure 3: Environments Setup



This is the 'Environments' page under DEPLOY, described on screen as a multi-stage deployment space used to test and publish an application without touching production. The layout is split into two clearly marked columns — a blue 'Stage' column and a green 'Production' column — which visually separates the testing environment from the live one.

Since no application has been added to either environment yet, both columns display 'No applications in Stage/Production yet', alongside a search bar and a central 'Add Application' button. The 'Version History', 'Manage', and 'Publish' controls in the top-right corner show that this is also where an application would eventually be promoted from Stage to Production.

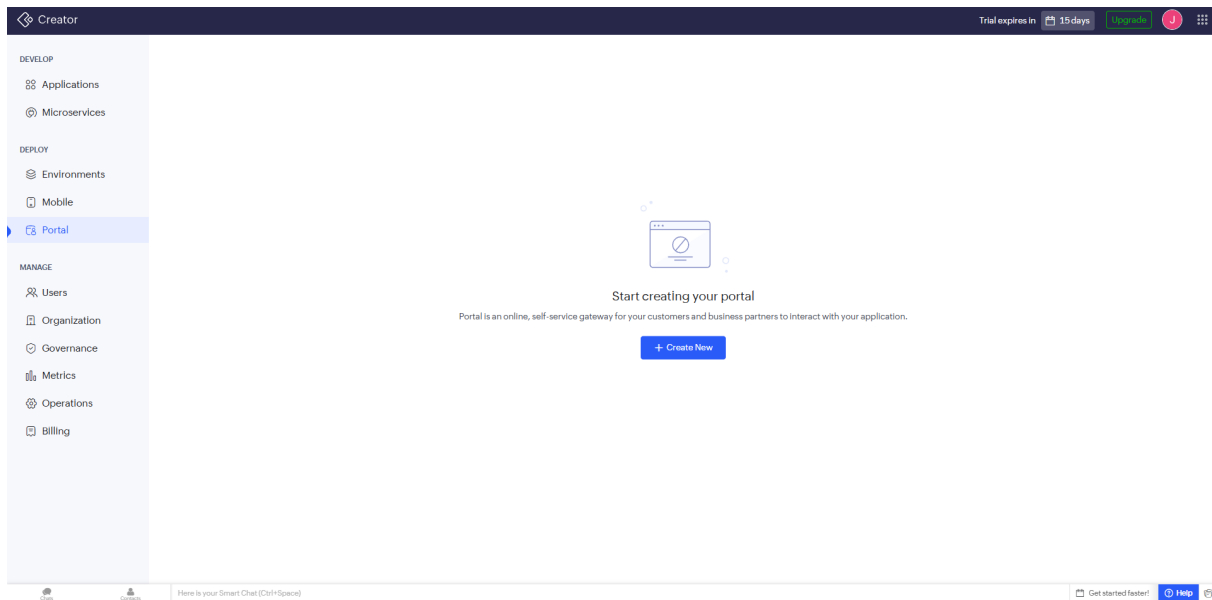
Figure 4: Mobile App Distribution



This page is the 'Mobile' section under DEPLOY, which covers how a Creator application can reach users as a native mobile app. Because the account is still on a trial plan, the page prompts an upgrade to download the application as a rebranded mobile app, while noting that the standard Zoho Creator-branded app can still be downloaded for free on Android or iOS.

A short bullet list explains what an upgrade unlocks: publishing to marketplaces such as the Play Store and App Store, distributing through MDM or a direct installation link, sending installation links by email, and white-labelling the app with the organization's own branding. Regional sales contact details for the USA, UK, Australia, and India are listed at the bottom for anyone considering an upgrade.

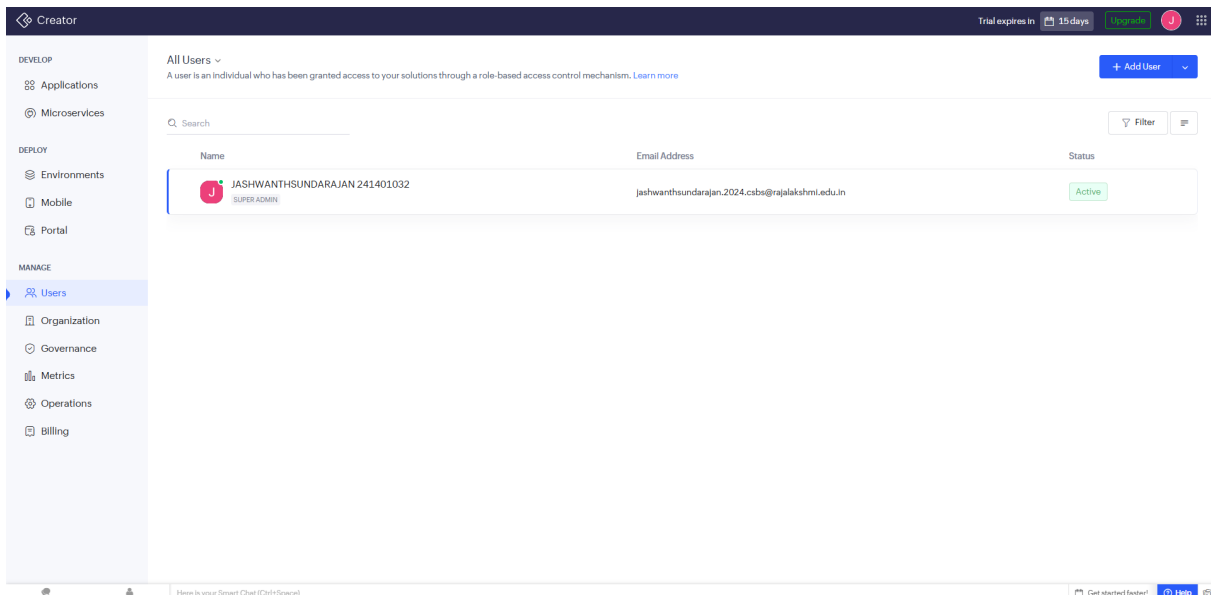
Figure 5: Portal – Getting Started



This screenshot shows the 'Portal' module, the third and last item under DEPLOY. A portal is described as an online, self-service gateway that lets customers and business partners interact directly with an application, making it a distinct external-facing channel separate from the internal Stage and Production environments seen earlier.

As no portal has been created yet, the console displays an illustrated empty state with the heading 'Start creating your portal' and a '+ Create New' button. Portals are typically used when an organization wants to expose specific forms or workflows to people outside the core team — for instance, letting clients submit requests — without giving them full access to the underlying application.

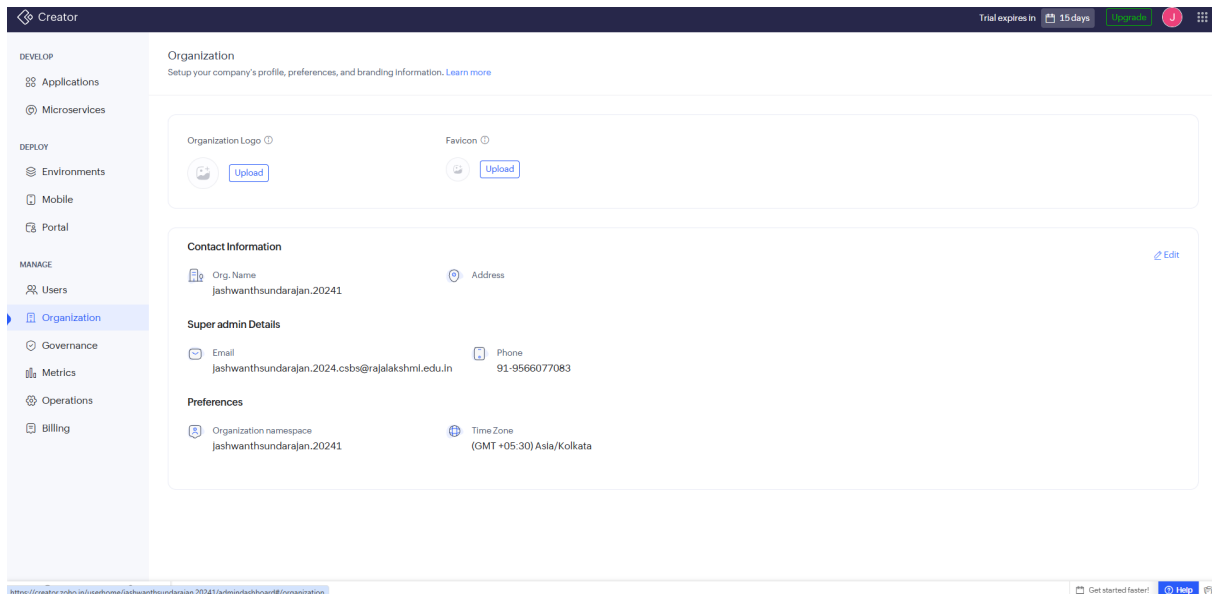
Figure 6: Users – Account Access



This is the 'Users' page under MANAGE, which lists everyone who has been granted access to the organization's applications through role-based access control. At this stage the list contains a single entry: 'JASHWANTHSUNDARAJAN 241401032', tagged with the SUPER ADMIN role, an 'Active' status, and the registered account email.

The page also provides 'Add User' and 'Filter' controls in the top-right corner, which would be used to invite additional collaborators and assign them specific roles as the application grows beyond a single-person trial setup.

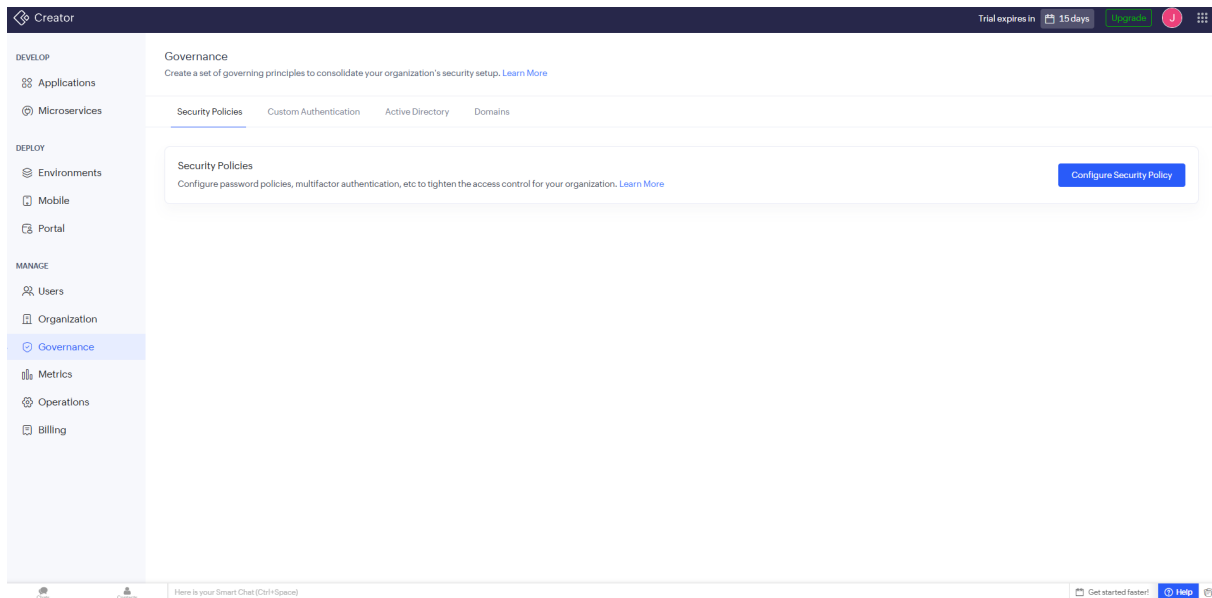
Figure 7: Organization Settings



This screen shows the 'Organization' page under MANAGE, which centralizes the company profile, branding, and preference settings in one place, as summarized by its description: 'Setup your company's profile, preferences, and branding information.' At the top, the page allows uploading an Organization Logo and a Favicon, both left as placeholders on this trial account.

The 'Contact Information' card lists the registered organization name, while 'Super Admin Details' shows the administrator's registered email and phone number, confirming account ownership. The 'Preferences' section records the organization namespace used to identify the account in URLs, along with the configured time zone — (GMT +05:30) Asia/Kolkata — which keeps all timestamps aligned to Indian Standard Time.

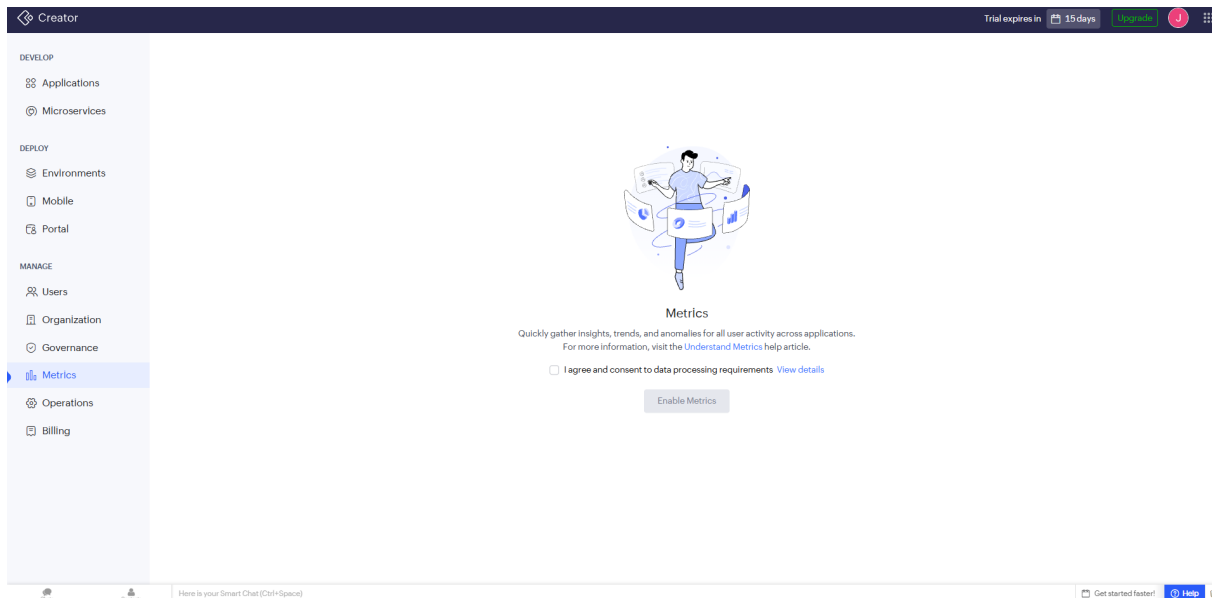
Figure 8: Governance – Security Policies



This is the 'Governance' page under MANAGE, introduced as a space to create governing principles that consolidate the organization's security setup. The page is split into four tabs — Security Policies, Custom Authentication, Active Directory, and Domains — with 'Security Policies' active by default.

This tab lets an administrator configure password rules and multi-factor authentication through the 'Configure Security Policy' button. The remaining tabs point to further capabilities: connecting external identity providers through Custom Authentication or Active Directory, and restricting sign-ups to verified organizational email domains, together forming a fairly complete identity and access-governance layer.

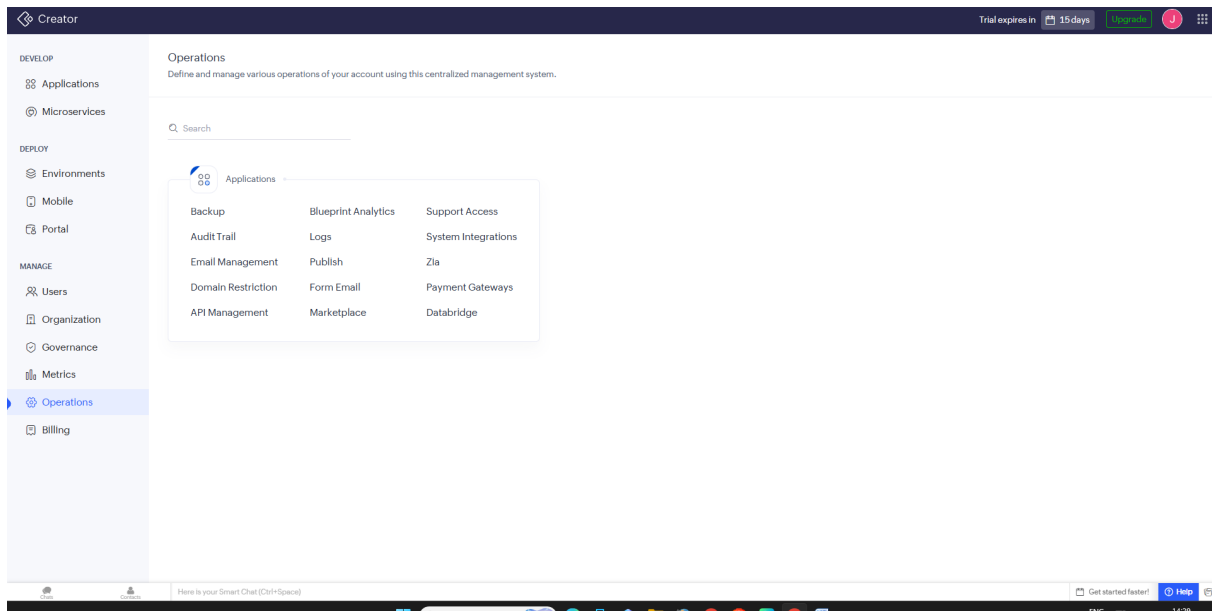
Figure 9: Metrics Overview



This screenshot shows the 'Metrics' page under MANAGE, introduced with the line: 'Quickly gather insights, trends, and anomalies for all user activity across applications', along with a link to a help article for further reading.

Before the feature can be switched on, Zoho Creator requires explicit consent to data processing through a checkbox ('I agree and consent to data processing requirements'), with a 'View details' link to review exactly what is processed. The 'Enable Metrics' button stays greyed out until this box is checked. Once enabled, this module would normally surface usage statistics and behavioural trends across every application in the organization.

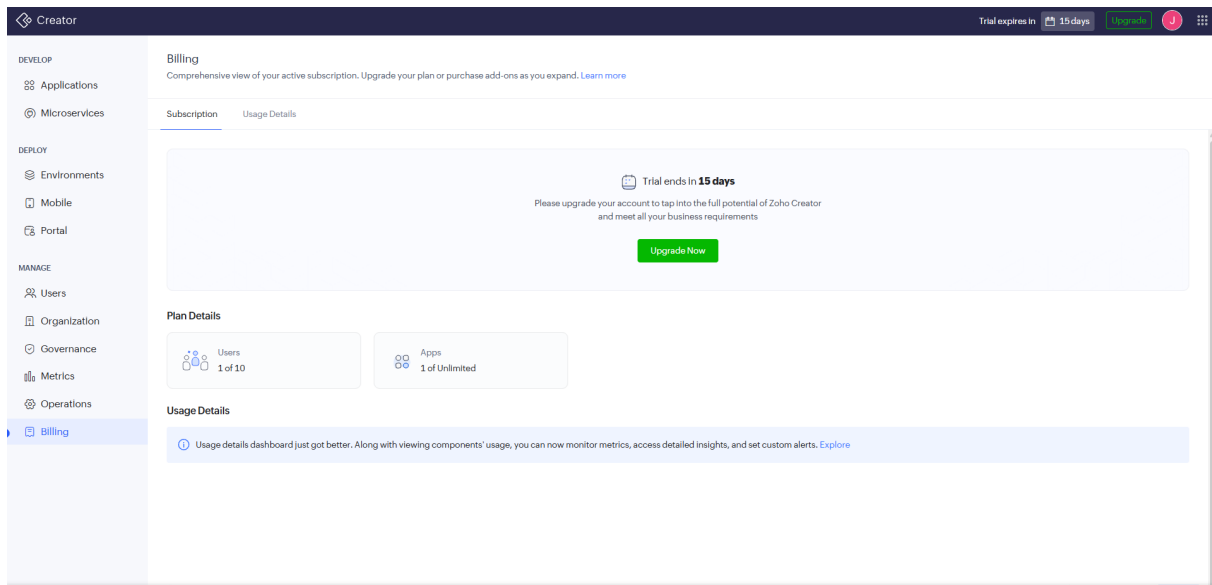
Figure 10: Operations Console



This page represents the 'Operations' section under MANAGE, described as a centralized system to define and manage various operations of the account. It is laid out as a searchable grid of administrative modules, including Backup, Audit Trail, Email Management, Domain Restriction, API Management, Blueprint Analytics, Logs, Publish, Form Email, Marketplace, Support Access, System Integrations, Zia (Zoho's built-in AI assistant), Payment Gateways, and Databridge.

Taken together, this dense grid shows how many operational and administrative levers are available once an application moves beyond a simple trial setup, making Operations the most feature-rich hub within the MANAGE category.

Figure 11: Billing and Subscription



This final screenshot shows the 'Billing' page under MANAGE, described as a comprehensive view of the active subscription, with options to upgrade the plan or add on capacity as usage grows. A countdown banner — 'Trial ends in 15 days' — sits alongside a green 'Upgrade Now' button.

Below that, the 'Plan Details' cards show current usage against the trial's limits: 1 of 10 permitted Users and 1 of Unlimited Apps, confirming the account is well within its allotted quota. An additional banner points to an improved 'Usage Details' dashboard for monitoring component-level metrics and setting custom alerts, tying application usage directly back to account billing.

6. Key Observations and Learning Outcomes

A few points stood out while exploring this Zoho Creator trial account:

- **One console, three layers:** Every development, deployment, and management function is reachable from the same left-hand navigation panel, organized consistently into DEVELOP, DEPLOY, and MANAGE.
- **Stage and Production stay separate:** Splitting the Environments page into Stage and Production columns encourages testing an application safely before it reaches real users.
- **More than one delivery channel:** A single application can be shipped through the web, a rebranded mobile app, or a self-service portal, without rebuilding it for each channel.
- **Security and monitoring are built in:** Dedicated Governance and Metrics modules show that access control and usage monitoring are treated as first-class parts of the platform, not afterthoughts.
- **Administration is centralized:** The Operations module alone bundles backup, audit trail, API management, payment gateways, and more, hinting at how the platform scales for real business use.
- **Trial limits are clearly flagged:** Features such as rebranded mobile apps and Metrics are gated behind an upgrade, and the console is upfront about this at the relevant screens rather than hiding it.

7. Conclusion

The screenshots and notes gathered in this report trace the full path through the Zoho Creator console — from creating an application and browsing microservices, through deployment across environments, mobile, and portal channels, to account-wide administration covering users, governance, metrics, operations, and billing. Working through each section first-hand gives a clear picture of how the platform structures the low-code application lifecycle inside one connected interface, and provides a solid base for building a real application on Zoho Creator going forward.